

We received the clear impression from grim customs officials and money-changers at the border that we had entered a part of the world still not entirely recovered from post-War economic depression. Roadside stands sold plaster garden statues, especially gnomes, and other wares were also for sale, judging by the surreptitious lifting of skirts to reveal totally bare flesh, from women sheltering under their umbrellas. I wondered where they would take their truck driver customers in a place where there seemed to be only road and forest.

Anthea's navigation skills took us promptly to the clean and pleasant Tumski Hotel on the Sand Island near the oldest part of Wrocław. I was immensely moved when I found that my room overlooked a canal of the Oder. This was a place of which mother had often spoken. Maria on the Sand (*die Sandkirche*) is still there, one of the large old Gothic red-brick churches that escaped bombing.

That Saturday afternoon, too late for lunch, we sampled Polish beer and vodka. We explored the famous Rynek, the central seventeenth-century market square with its famed Gothic town hall where American soldiers had stolen the gold from the astrological clock. The bombed-out buildings had been restored, but they were too garishly painted to revive a sense of their history. The adjoining salt square now mostly sells flowers.

We wondered at how few smiling faces there were, and were puzzled by how little German or English anyone spoke. Why was there so little tourism? Only a pair of elegant teenagers had fluent German. We turned down their offers of pornographic pictures and sexual experiences.

We covered enough of the area to get a strong impression of a once-lively city devastated by War and hastily repaired. These were convenient reconstructions, done without an eye to matching styles.

I was especially anxious to find out where Neumarkt Platz had been. That evening at the hotel, I kept going to the window and trying to imagine my mother as a young woman taking an evening stroll with a companion along the banks of the Oder. But this was autumn. Thick mists hung above the water. Few people were out walking.

On Sunday we set out seriously to find the location of the old square. We walked through once-stately streets, past the Metropole Hotel from where Hitler had addressed the crowds, to the Ethnographic Museum. This proved disappointing. The contents of two rooms were a mere